

LOVE THAT LASTS

A Scripture-Based Communication Workbook
for Christian Couples

Better communication = Stronger marriage

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GOD'S DESIGN FOR MARRIAGE COMMUNICATION

God created marriage for companionship (Genesis 2:18).

Communication is the lifeblood of this companionship.

Key principles from Scripture:

- Be quick to listen (James 1:19)
- Speak truth in love (Ephesians 4:15)
- Build each other up (1 Thessalonians 5:11)
- Be kind and tenderhearted (Ephesians 4:32)
- Do not let the sun go down on anger (Ephesians 4:26)

God's goal is not conflict-free marriage -
it's a marriage where conflict leads to growth.

This workbook will help you:

1. Understand each other's communication style
2. Learn to listen with love
3. Express needs without attacking
4. Resolve conflict the biblical way
5. Build a lasting communication covenant

COMMUNICATION STYLE - PARTNER 1

Rate yourself 1-5 (1=never, 5=always):

I express my feelings openly	1	2	3	4	5
I listen without interrupting	1	2	3	4	5
I raise my voice when frustrated	1	2	3	4	5
I shut down during conflict (withdraw)	1	2	3	4	5
I bring up past issues in arguments	1	2	3	4	5
I apologize when I'm wrong	1	2	3	4	5
I ask clarifying questions	1	2	3	4	5
I assume I know what my partner thinks	1	2	3	4	5
I express appreciation daily	1	2	3	4	5
I pray with/for my spouse regularly	1	2	3	4	5

My communication strength:

Area I most need to grow:

COMMUNICATION STYLE - PARTNER 2

Rate yourself 1-5 (1=never, 5=always):

I express my feelings openly	1	2	3	4	5
I listen without interrupting	1	2	3	4	5
I raise my voice when frustrated	1	2	3	4	5
I shut down during conflict (withdraw)	1	2	3	4	5
I bring up past issues in arguments	1	2	3	4	5
I apologize when I'm wrong	1	2	3	4	5
I ask clarifying questions	1	2	3	4	5
I assume I know what my partner thinks	1	2	3	4	5
I express appreciation daily	1	2	3	4	5
I pray with/for my spouse regularly	1	2	3	4	5

My communication strength:

Area I most need to grow:

ACTIVE LISTENING AS LOVE

James 1:19 - Be quick to listen

ACTIVE LISTENING means:

- Put down your phone
- Make eye contact
- Don't formulate your response while they talk
- Reflect back: 'What I hear you saying is...'
- Ask: 'Did I understand that correctly?'
- Validate: 'That makes sense that you'd feel that way'

LISTENING KILLERS:

- Defending yourself before they finish
- Minimizing: 'It's not that bad'
- Problem-solving before they ask for solutions
- Bringing up your own issue in response

Practice: Take turns sharing for 3 minutes each.

The listener can ONLY reflect back. No responding.

I-STATEMENT PRACTICE #1

Ephesians 4:15 - Speaking truth in love

Formula: 'When [situation], I feel [emotion] because [reason].

I need [request].'

Situation 1:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 2:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 3:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

I-STATEMENT PRACTICE #2

Ephesians 4:15 - Speaking truth in love

Formula: 'When [situation], I feel [emotion] because [reason].

I need [request].'

Situation 1:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 2:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 3:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

I-STATEMENT PRACTICE #3

Ephesians 4:15 - Speaking truth in love

Formula: 'When [situation], I feel [emotion] because [reason].

I need [request].'

Situation 1:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 2:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 3:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

I-STATEMENT PRACTICE #4

Ephesians 4:15 - Speaking truth in love

Formula: 'When [situation], I feel [emotion] because [reason].

I need [request].'

Situation 1:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 2:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 3:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

I-STATEMENT PRACTICE #5

Ephesians 4:15 - Speaking truth in love

Formula: 'When [situation], I feel [emotion] because [reason].

I need [request].'

Situation 1:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 2:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

Situation 3:

When (what happened):

I feel (emotion):

Because (why it matters):

I need (specific request):

THINKING TRAPS IN MARRIAGE

Mind Reading:

Example: 'She's angry because she hates me'

Correction: Ask, don't assume! (Proverbs 18:13)

Catastrophizing:

Example: 'One fight means our marriage is over'

Correction: One conflict is not the end (Love bears all - 1 Cor 13:7)

All-or-Nothing:

Example: 'He NEVER helps' / 'She ALWAYS nags'

Correction: Avoid always/never. Be specific. (Eph 4:25)

Scorekeeper:

Example: 'I did X so she should do Y'

Correction: Love doesn't keep score (1 Cor 13:5)

Negative Filter:

Example: Only seeing what's wrong

Correction: Think on what is good (Phil 4:8)

CONFLICT DE-ESCALATION WITH PRAYER PAUSE

1. RECOGNIZE: 'We're escalating' (watch for raised voices, blame)
2. PAUSE: 'I need 20 minutes. I love you and I'll come back.'
3. PRAY: Separately. 'God, help me see their heart, not just words.'
4. SELF-SOOTHE: Breathe, walk, journal. Don't rehearse arguments.
5. RETURN: Come back calmer. Start with 'I love you.'
6. REPAIR: 'I'm sorry for my part. Can we try again?'

RULES OF ENGAGEMENT (agree on these together):

- No name-calling
- No bringing up the past
- No 'always' or 'never'
- Either can call a timeout (not avoidance!)
- Pray before resuming
- Touch if possible (hold hands during hard talks)

REPAIR ATTEMPTS

Matthew 5:23-24 - Seek reconciliation

Repair attempts are bids to de-escalate. They work!

- 'I'm sorry. That came out wrong.'
- 'Can we start over?'
- 'You're right about that part.'
- 'I love you even when we disagree.'
- 'Let me try to say that better.'
- 'I can see this from your side.'
- 'We're on the same team.'
- 'Can I have a do-over?'
- 'I hear you. I'm listening.'
- 'Let's pray about this together.'

Our favorite repair phrases:

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 1

ROSES (What went well this week?):

THORNS (What was hard?):

PRAYERS (What do we need God's help with?):

APPRECIATION (Something I love about you):

NEXT WEEK (What can we do better?):

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 2

ROSES (What went well this week?):

THORNS (What was hard?):

PRAYERS (What do we need God's help with?):

APPRECIATION (Something I love about you):

NEXT WEEK (What can we do better?):

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 3

ROSES (What went well this week?):

THORNS (What was hard?):

PRAYERS (What do we need God's help with?):

APPRECIATION (Something I love about you):

NEXT WEEK (What can we do better?):

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 4

ROSES (What went well this week?):

THORNS (What was hard?):

PRAYERS (What do we need God's help with?):

APPRECIATION (Something I love about you):

NEXT WEEK (What can we do better?):

WEEKLY COUPLES CHECK-IN - WEEK 5

ROSES (What went well this week?):

THORNS (What was hard?):

PRAYERS (What do we need God's help with?):

APPRECIATION (Something I love about you):

NEXT WEEK (What can we do better?):

DATE NIGHT CONVERSATION STARTERS

20 Faith-Based Questions

1. What's one way God has grown us as a couple?
2. What's your favorite memory of us this year?
3. How can I pray for you this week?
4. What dream do you have that we haven't talked about?
5. What's something I do that makes you feel loved?
6. If we could serve together somewhere, where would it be?
7. What does your ideal Saturday look like?
8. What Bible verse describes our marriage right now?
9. What are you most grateful for about our family?
10. What's one thing you'd like us to do more of?
11. How do you feel closest to God?
12. What's a goal you want us to work toward?
13. When do you feel most loved by me?
14. What's something new you'd like to try together?
15. What legacy do we want to leave our family?
16. What's your love language this season?
17. How can I support your calling/gifts?
18. What's one thing I could improve as a spouse?
19. What couple do you admire and why?
20. Let's pray together right now about _____.

OUR COMMUNICATION COVENANT

We, the undersigned, commit before God to:

- ☐ Listen with our full attention
- ☐ Speak truth in love, not anger
- ☐ Never use words as weapons
- ☐ Seek to understand before being understood
- ☐ Pray together when conflict arises
- ☐ Forgive as Christ forgave us
- ☐ Assume the best about each other's motives
- ☐ Never threaten divorce in an argument
- ☐ Build each other up, not tear down
- ☐ Keep growing in communication together

Partner 1: _____ Date: _____

Partner 2: _____ Date: _____

'Above all, love each other deeply.' - 1 Peter 4:8